Grammar for Data Description

Tense, prepositions, comparisons and linking: the grammar that matters most in Task 1.

Which tense?

DATA	TENSE	EXAMPLE
Recorded, even last year	past simple	*Cycling rose to 34% in 2020.*
Projected (dashed line)	future form	*The share is expected to reach 45% by 2030.*
Complete before a past point	past perfect + by	*By 2021, the share had risen to 9%.*

Irregular verbs: rise, **rose**, risen · fall, **fell**, fallen · grow, **grew**, grown.

Prepositions for amounts

- **by** the size of the change: rose **by** 22 percentage points
- **to** the end point: fell **to** 37%
- **from … to** both points: **from** 58% **to** 37%
- **at** a level: stood **at** 12%, peaked **at** 42%
- **of** after a noun: a rise **of** 7 points

Verb + **by**, noun + **of**.

Comparatives and superlatives

Comparative for two things: higher than, lower than, sharper than, more gradual than, twice as high as.

Superlative for the whole set: the highest, the sharpest, the most rapid. It usually needs *the*, but a possessive replaces it: *Spain's highest figure*.

Never more higher, the highest than, gradualer.

Linking two trends

In one sentence: while, whereas
Car use fell to 37%, whereas cycling rose to 34%.

In a new sentence: In contrast, By contrast, However,
Car use fell. In contrast, cycling rose.

Subject–verb agreement

The subject is the first noun, not the one after *of*:

The percentage of journeys **was** higher.
The percentage of journeys were higher.

Band 7+: relative clauses

- *Cycling rose to 34%, **which** was its highest figure.*
- *The sharpest rise came between 2010 and 2015, **when** cycling grew by 7 points.*
- *The graph shows three sources, **only one of which** grew throughout.*

After a comma, use *which*, never *that*. Use *when* for years, not *where*.